

Vaginal Estrogen Therapy

Patient Information · Low-dose, local treatment for dryness and bladder symptoms

WARWIKI

Vaginal estrogen is a **low dose of estrogen placed in the vagina** as a cream, tablet or ring. It treats dryness, irritation, painful sex and bladder symptoms caused by low estrogen after menopause. It works where it is placed, and very little reaches the rest of the body.

What It Treats

After menopause, low estrogen thins and dries the tissue of the vagina and urethra (the tube you urinate from). This is called **genitourinary syndrome of menopause (GSM)**. Vaginal estrogen helps rebuild that tissue. It can:

- Ease **dryness, burning, itching** and **painful sex**
- Help with a sudden, strong **urge to urinate**
- Lower the chance of **repeat urinary tract infections**

Is It Safe?

For most people, yes. It is **very low-dose and local**. This is different from estrogen pills or patches for hot flashes. With low-dose products, you do not need a second hormone (progestogen) to protect the womb.

Warning labels were updated in 2026 and **differ by product**. Some still carry a boxed warning. If you have had **breast cancer**, it can often still be used after talking with your cancer doctor. This matters most if you take an aromatase inhibitor.

Learn the Terms

GSM

Genitourinary syndrome of menopause: dryness, thinning and bladder symptoms from low estrogen.

Vaginal estrogen

Low-dose estrogen placed in the vagina as a cream, tablet or ring.

Local

Works where it is placed. Pills and patches work in the whole body.

Maintenance dose

The lower dose you keep using after the first few weeks.

Aromatase inhibitor

A type of pill used after some breast cancers.

Moisturizer or lubricant

Products without hormones that can be used along with it.

How long before it helps? The tissue gets thicker over the first few weeks to about 3 months, so improvement builds slowly. It works only while you keep using it. Symptoms tend to come back if you stop, so it is meant as ongoing care.

How to Use It

- 1 Starting:** most creams and tablets are used **every night for about 2 weeks**.
- 2 Keeping it up:** then usually **1 to 3 times a week**. The ring is replaced every 3 months.
- 3** Use it at **bedtime** so it stays in place. Wash your hands before and after.
- 4** Keep using it for as long as it helps. Your team will tell you the exact schedule for your product.

Forms and Other Choices

- **Cream:** dose measured with an applicator
- **Tablet or insert:** a pre-measured dose
- **Ring:** changed every 3 months, easy if a cream is hard to use. Ask first if you have prolapse or a narrow vagina; the ring can rub.
- **Other medicines:** a nightly vaginal insert (prasterone, which the body partly turns into estrogen) or a daily pill (ospemifene). Each has its own warnings.
- **Vaginal laser:** in studies it worked no better than a sham (pretend) treatment. The FDA has not cleared any device for this use, and a 2025 US guideline finds the evidence does not support it.

Good to Know

- You can add a **moisturizer or lubricant** for extra comfort.
- Some mild discharge or irritation when starting is common and usually settles.

Call the office that is treating you if you have:

- Any **vaginal bleeding after menopause**. Always have this checked.
- A new breast lump
- Irritation that gets worse instead of better

Go to an emergency department if:

- You have chest pain, trouble breathing, or a painful, swollen leg
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- 1.** Vaginal estrogen is a low-dose, local treatment for dryness, painful sex and bladder symptoms.
- 2.** It helps only while you keep using it.
- 3.** Talk with your team about any cancer history. Always report bleeding after menopause.